

Turning the Light On

The Progressive Era • 1890–1920 | Standards US.08, US.09, US.10, US.11, US.12, US.13, US.14, US.15, US.16, US.17, US.18

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

When a booming country leaves millions behind, who decides to fix it — and how? Progressive-era Americans fought over whether the answer was charity, protest, journalism, unions, or the government itself. Which of them actually moved the country?

Hold this question the whole unit. You'll answer it at the end — in your own words, from the evidence.

1 Mission Vocabulary

Write what each word means as you meet it in the stories (definitions shown).

Social Darwinism A misuse of evolution claiming the rich deserved wealth and the poor deserved poverty by 'survival of the fittest.'

trust A giant combination of companies that controlled an industry and limited competition.

suffrage The right to vote.

muckraker A journalist who investigated and exposed corruption and abuse to spark reform.

collective bargaining Workers negotiating as a group (a union) for better pay, hours, and safety.

initiative & referendum Reforms letting citizens propose and vote directly on laws.

2 Flight Log — every stop

One entry per landing. Jot what you *notice*, then answer the crew's debrief — the point isn't a right answer, it's your read of the evidence.

#	What Spark shows you & the crew's debrief	Key (one defensible read)
1	Analyze Social Darwinism as a justification for inequality, and compare Washington's and Du Bois's strategies for Black advancement. Notice: Somebody tells you the rich are rich because they're simply better — stronger, smarter, more deserving — and the poor earned their poverty by... Debrief: Washington and Du Bois wanted the same goal but chose opposite strategies. Explain each strategy in one sentence, then argue which one you think fit the dangers of 1900 better — using evidence.	Washington: build economic strength and skills first, accept segregation temporarily, expect rights to follow. Du Bois: demand full civil and political rights and higher education immediately, and protest. Strong answers weigh the deadly risks of open protest in the Jim Crow South against the moral and practical cost of accepting segregation — and take a defensible position with evidence.
2	Explain how farmers (Granger/Populist) and workers (labor unions) organized to fight railroads and industry — and what it cost them. Notice: One company sets the price, and you have no choice but to pay it — sound familiar? For Anna's family, that company was the railroad, and the price... Debrief: Farmers and industrial workers used different tactics but shared one core idea. Name the shared idea, then give one tactic each group used and one risk each faced.	Shared idea: strength in numbers / collective action. Farmers used cooperatives and lobbying for Granger Laws (risk: courts and railroads overturning regulations). Workers used strikes, collective bargaining, and boycotts (risk: violent suppression and defeat, as at Homestead in 1892).
3	Analyze how trusts concentrated power, and how Roosevelt's Square Deal and Wilson's New Freedom used government to check it. Notice: Imagine one company owns the app, the phone, the store, and the road to the store — so there's nowhere else to go and no price but theirs. That... Debrief: Trace one path from problem to fix: start with the power of the trusts, and explain how journalism and government together checked it. Name at least one muckraker and one law or agency.	Trusts concentrated power and hurt competition and consumers. Ida Tarbell's exposé of Standard Oil mobilized public opinion; Roosevelt used the Sherman Act to bust trusts and passed the Pure Food and Drug Act, and Wilson added the Clayton Act, FTC, and Federal Reserve. Strong answers connect the voice (journalism/public pressure) to the specific government response.
4	Analyze industrial working conditions — child labor, sweatshops, and the Triangle fire — and the reforms they provoked. Notice: 146 people went to work one morning and never came home — most of them girls not much older than you, some younger. The factory doors were locked... Debrief: The Triangle fire is often called a turning point. Explain what conditions caused so many deaths, and how the tragedy changed what the government required of factories.	Deaths were worsened by locked doors, overcrowding, and inadequate fire escapes in an unregulated factory. The public outrage led New York's Factory Investigating Commission to enact landmark workplace-safety laws (1911–1914). Strong answers connect the specific unsafe conditions to the specific policy response.
5	Explain how muckrakers exposed abuses and mobilized public support for reform. Notice: You post a video of something wrong — a scam, a cover-up — and by morning it's everywhere and somebody powerful has to answer for it. That... Debrief: Explain how a single book led to a federal law in 1906 — and why Sinclair considered the result a partial failure.	Sinclair's 'The Jungle' exposed the filthy meatpacking industry; public disgust pressured Congress to pass the Pure Food and Drug Act and Meat Inspection Act. Sinclair saw it as partial failure because he wanted to help exploited workers, but the reforms addressed food safety, not labor conditions.
6	Analyze Progressive democratic reforms that expanded citizen control (initiative, referendum, recall, direct primaries, 16th & 17th Amendments). Notice: What if you could skip the middleman and vote directly on the rule itself — no crooked politician required? That's not a fantasy app. It's what... Debrief: Choose two Progressive democratic reforms and explain how each one shifted power away from political machines or state legislatures and toward ordinary citizens.	Examples: the initiative/referendum let citizens make laws directly (bypassing corrupt legislatures); the recall let voters remove officials; direct primaries let voters, not bosses, choose candidates; the 17th Amendment moved senator selection from state legislatures to the voters. Strong answers name two and explain the power shift for each.
7	Analyze the women's suffrage movement and the ratification of the 19th Amendment — decided in Tennessee. Notice: It comes down to one vote. One state left to make women's suffrage the law of the land, and that state is Tennessee. The count is tied. And the... Debrief: The 19th Amendment is a triumph and an unfinished one. Explain how women won the vote (including Tennessee's deciding role) AND why the victory was incomplete for many Black women.	Women won through decades of organizing — parades, lobbying, civil disobedience — culminating in Tennessee's deciding ratification on August 18, 1920 (Harry Burn's vote). It was incomplete because Jim Crow laws (poll taxes, literacy tests, intimidation) still blocked many Black women from voting for decades. Strong answers hold the triumph and the limit together.

S Source Detective

Find this primary source in Unit 2 of your book, then work it like an investigator: **dubois-souls**

1. Who made this, and when? Whose point of view does it show — and whose is missing?
2. Spark's question: *Both men were brilliant, brave, and right about some things. Instead of picking a 'winner,' ask: what did each strategy risk, and what did each...*
3. What does this source prove — and what does it *not* prove on its own?

Teacher note: US.08/09. Steelman both leaders; do not let students flatten Washington into a coward or Du Bois into a radical. Fisk is the Tennessee anchor.

A The Arc of the Union — *your call*

For each milestone, decide: did it move the country **toward** its founding promise — liberty and equality *for all* — or **away**? There's no answer key. Mark your read and back it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	Historians' read (one reading, not the answer)
1892	Homestead Strike crushed	Setback Historians broadly treat the violent defeat of the Homestead strikers as a major setback for organized labor and worker power.
1895	Atlanta Compromise (Washington)	Mixed Genuinely debated: historians disagree over whether Washington's accommodation strategy protected Black lives and built strength, or postponed the...
1906	Pure Food & Drug and Meat Inspection Acts	Climb Widely regarded as landmark consumer-protection laws and a step toward a fairer, safer market.
1911	Triangle Shirtwaist fire	Setback A preventable industrial tragedy broadly marked as a low point that exposed the human cost of unregulated industry.
1913	17th Amendment (direct election of senators)	Climb Broadly seen as an expansion of direct democracy and citizen control.
1914	Clayton Act & Federal Trade Commission	Climb Widely treated as strengthening antitrust enforcement and market fairness.
1920	19th Amendment ratified in Tennessee	Climb One of the largest single expansions of the franchise in U.S. history, though Jim Crow still blocked many Black women in practice.

B Debrief & Closing Argument

If Unit 1 was the country growing fast and leaving people behind, Unit 2 is the country arguing about what it owes the people it left. Watch...

Closing question: Across this unit you saw at least five kinds of power try to fix a broken system: charity, protest, unions, journalism, and the law. Pick the two you think actually moved the country the most, cite evidence from the unit, and defend your ranking. There's no answer key — make the case.

Facilitation: There is no single correct verdict — students must choose moments and defend a direction with evidence. Reward a claim that holds competing truths (opportunity *and* injustice in the same years) over a tidy one-sided answer.

Back to the Essential Question — your answer now:

Answers vary; look for direct use of unit evidence and a defensible position, not a memorized "right" answer.